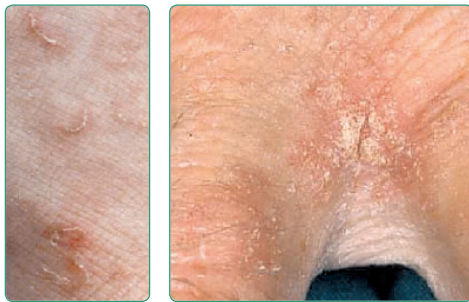


## Patient presentation

Scabies is a common infestation of the skin with the mite *Sarcoptes scabiei*. It is contagious and spreads within a family, a school or the elderly in hospital or nursing homes.

Clinical features include non-specific excoriated eruption especially on hands, buttocks and breasts.



## GP

Patients with scabies should generally be managed in Primary Care.

Management

- Treat all areas of the body except face and scalp.
- Treat all body sites in infants, the elderly and the immunosuppressed.
- Malathion aqueous lotion applied all over and left on for 24 hours.
- Permethrin 5% dermal cream applied all over and left on for eight hours.
- Reapply to hands after washing.
- Repeat treatment after one week.
- Advise patient to change and wash all bed linen and underwear.

## Diagnostic tips

- Itch in the absence of previous skin disease, especially at night.
- History of contact with infected individuals.
- High risk occupations e.g. nursing the elderly.
- Crusted scabies in the elderly may be mistaken for dermatitis.

## Therapeutic tips

- Treat all household members and other contacts whether symptomatic or not.
- Avoid irritant alcohol-based lotions.
- Children under two years: use permethrin and shorten treatment duration. Advice from pharmacist or health visitor.
- Pregnant and lactating women: use malathion in aqueous base.
- Use crotamiton cream or calamine lotion for post scabetic itch which may persist for several weeks.
- Itch may be absent in crusted scabies which is highly infectious, therefore isolate patient.
- Involve public and environmental health staff if outbreak is in hospital, nursing or residential home, school, nursery or other group setting.

## Dermatology Consultant

### Criteria for referral

- Diagnostic uncertainty.
- Ineffective therapy.
- Secondary infection or dermatitis.
- Crusted (Norwegian) scabies
- Immunosuppressed patients.

## Patient Information

NHS Inform [www.nhsinform.co.uk](http://www.nhsinform.co.uk)  
NHS24 Tel: 08454 24 24 24  
Text phone: 18001 08454 24 24 24